



Inspired by the women, many men joined the protest in support.

◀ THE WOMEN'S MARCH

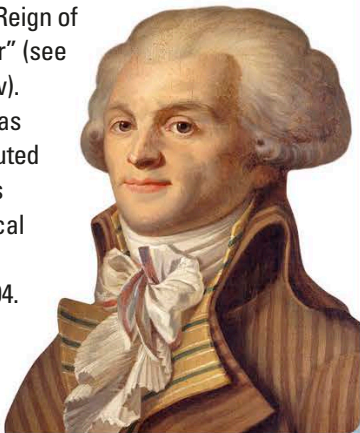
On October 5, 1789, a group of around 7,000 protesters—most of them women—marched on the royal palace of Versailles to protest the high price of bread. The numbers swelled and the king was forced to meet some of their demands. The march's success helped weaken royal power.

1750–1900

MAXIMILIEN ROBESPIERRE

Robespierre (1758–1794) was an influential leader of the French Revolution who campaigned to end the monarchy and to give equal rights to all men. He led the new parliament established after the revolution but soon became the brutal architect of the “Reign of Terror” (see below).

He was executed by his political rivals in 1794.



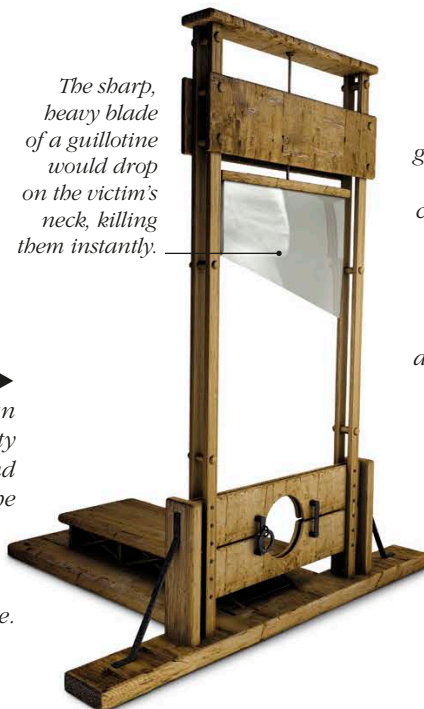
EXECUTION OF LOUIS XVI ▶

In August 1792, King Louis XVI was imprisoned, and soon afterward the French monarchy was abolished.

Louis was charged with treason and on January 21, 1793, he was executed by guillotine. Queen Marie Antoinette was executed nine months later.

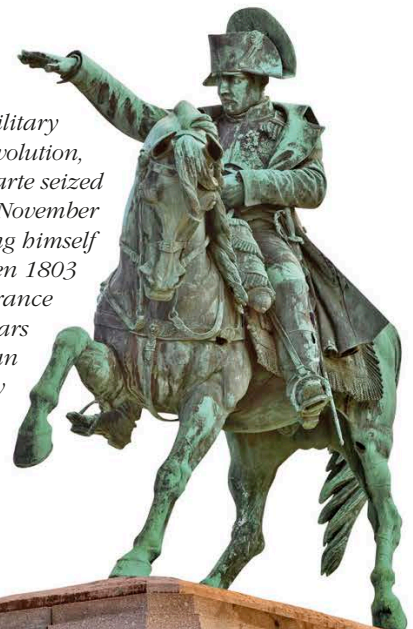


The sharp, heavy blade of a guillotine would drop on the victim's neck, killing them instantly.



NAPOLEON BONAPARTE ▶

A leading military general during the revolution, Napoleon Bonaparte seized control of France in November 1799, later declaring himself the emperor. Between 1803 and 1815, he led France into a series of wars against other European powers, briefly conquering much of western Europe.



THE REIGN OF TERROR ▶

Known in French as La Terreur, the Reign of Terror was a period of ruthless brutality that started after the king was beheaded and lasted until mid-1794. During this time the revolutionary government, led by Maximilien Robespierre, imprisoned thousands of aristocrats and other “enemies of the revolution” and executed them by guillotine.